Asad Ikram

MSc Data Analytics (Distinction), University of Portsmouth · Chevening Scholar 2024/25
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PROFILE

Researcher and data engineer working on social media data: how people behave on platforms, and what platform traces can and cannot measure. I bring computational methods to social questions (an MSc dissertation that became a methods paper on measuring opinion across platforms), eight years of coding, modelling and data wrangling on large multilingual web data (from 300+ freelance clients to companies in nine countries), and hands-on work with agentic and generative AI. I want to study when toxicity, sentiment and polarisation measured from social media, LLMs and surveys can be compared across platforms, languages and countries, and how to correct them when they cannot.

RESEARCH

Ikram, A. and Haig, E. "Is the Platform Part of the Measurement? A Protocol and Simulation Study for Cross-Platform Equivalence of Machine-Labelled Policy Sentiment." Preprint, arXiv:2610.16757 (2026), arxiv.org/abs/2610.16757. Treats each platform as a survey mode and applies generalizability theory, measurement invariance and differential item functioning, and score linking to machine-labelled text. I built the simulation: with known ground truth, pooling platform scores at face value gives the wrong sign of daily aggregate sentiment on roughly a quarter of days, from measurement differences alone. *No peer-reviewed publications to date.*

EDUCATION

Sep 2024 - Sep 2025
awarded 8 Dec 2025

MSc Data Analytics, Distinction. University of Portsmouth, United Kingdom. Chevening Scholar. Credit-weighted average 70.5/100; master's project 78/100. Supervisor: Dr Ella Haig. Modules included Big Data and Machine Learning, Intelligent Data and Text Analytics, Explainable AI and Data Management.

Dissertation: *Cross-Platform Sentiment Analysis of Public Reaction to UK Economic Policies*. About 279,000 public posts from X/Twitter, Reddit, YouTube and Quora, under university ethics approval (TETHIC-2025-111094). Fine-tuned BERT against BiLSTM and lexicon baselines; 200 posts hand-labelled; McNemar and bootstrap tests, chi-square tests across topics, Prophet forecasting.

Aug 2017 - Jan 2022

BS Computer Science. National University of Computer and Emerging Sciences (FAST-NUCES), Pakistan.
Courses included Probability and Statistics, Linear Algebra, Calculus I and II, Numerical Methods, Design and Analysis of Algorithms, Database Systems and Applied Machine Learning.

EXPERIENCE

Dec 2024 - present
part-time, remote

Data Engineer, M+C Saatchi Fluency, London. Social media analysis for global brands including Amazon, Ford, Nike and Reckitt, and for UK government.

- Analyst on a twelve-month discourse study (100,845 Brandwatch and 170,542 Reddit mentions): BERTopic codebook, versioned LLM tagging.
- Social data collection, labelling and tagging, text and sentiment analysis with AI/ML, forum sourcing and pipeline architecture; a weekly pipeline of 2.2 million rows.
- Built a self-healing agent that diagnoses a broken forum crawler, regenerates it and tests it on live pages, and a builder agent that creates new crawlers, across a fleet of 64; secured with prompt fencing and approval gates, and I approve each merge.

2025 - present
part-time

Co-Founder and Chief Technology Officer, Artemis AI, United Kingdom. Social-media intelligence for creators and businesses.

- Processed 3 million+ Facebook and Instagram comments (111,000+ posts) on AWS: Meta Graph API collectors, an Apache Iceberg warehouse, and an LLM labelling cascade designed to escalate from our own NLP models to DeepSeek and then Claude.
- Building a 48-model system for the 15 December 2026 beta: comment toxicity, intent and topic classifiers tested on blind human-labelled sets; a storm detector for bursts of hostile comments; spam, bot, language and banter filters so dialect is not read as toxicity; community detection and match scoring on the network of pages; best-time, engagement-outlook and post-health models; image and video understanding (OCR, CLIP, Whisper); and Art-E, a retrieval-based advisor on Amazon Bedrock.
- Lead a team of five across models, AI/ML, deployment, app development and design; take part in pitching.

Feb 2022 - Aug 2024
full-time

Associate Software Engineer, then Data Engineer, then Senior Data Engineer, Dubizzle Labs (Dubizzle, Bayut, Zameen, OLX), Lahore. Promoted twice in about two and a half years.

- Data modelling and machine learning for competitor-intelligence dashboards: what people discussed, how much volume each site carried, and what worked on each platform and in which region.

- Designed the company's first web-scraping architecture on AWS: 15 markets, English, Arabic, Urdu and Hindi; led a team of three engineers in scraping and data warehousing. Owned a data-warehousing product end to end.

May 2023 - present contract, remote

Data Engineer (contract), Fix.com, Canada. OCR-based machine learning to parse parts catalogues from PDFs; models to backfill missing parts data; since June 2026, sole designer and operator of the crawler platform (about 10 million rows across 82 datasets).

2018 - 2026 remote

Other data engineering work. Lead Data Engineer, VendueTech, Ireland (2025: Azure-to-AWS migration, team of three); Data Engineer, Prefe, Milan (2024); CXG, Dubai (production crawlers, pytest QA); Metoda, Germany; web-scraping architecture for a US start-up and businesses in the Netherlands and Lithuania; earlier work for companies in India and Japan; freelance on Fiverr from 2018, starting during my BS: 300+ clients.

SKILLS

Coding

Python (pandas, Scrapy, PyTorch, FastAPI, pytest), SQL, PySpark; Git, GitHub and CI.

Data and databases

Collection from APIs and the open web at scale; cleaning, deduplication, joins and validation; PostgreSQL, Redshift, Athena, DynamoDB, Apache Iceberg; AWS, Docker, Kubernetes.

Modelling and statistics

Hypothesis tests (McNemar, chi-square), bootstrap, Prophet forecasting; simulation with known ground truth; generalizability theory, measurement invariance and DIF, score linking; validating machine and LLM labels against human-labelled sets.

NLP and AI

Fine-tuning encoder classifiers (BERT, XLM-R, DistilBERT, DeBERTa-v3); LLM-assisted labelling (Claude, DeepSeek); OCR, CLIP and Whisper; BERTopic; LIME and integrated gradients; building AI agents; AI coding assistants (Claude Code, OpenAI Codex), where I write the specification and tests and decide what merges.

AWARDS, COMMUNITY AND LANGUAGES

Chevening

Chevening Scholar 2024/25 (UK Government's global scholarship, which funded the MSc), awarded for helping students and junior colleagues into freelance and remote careers and for a proposed cross-platform social media analytics system to give government evidence of public opinion.

Community

Author and maintainer of web-scraping-guide.com (since May 2026), a free public guide to web data collection. Helped university students start freelance careers and junior colleagues at Dubizzle into remote work; two of them got remote jobs.

Languages

Urdu (native); English (working language; MSc taught and assessed in English, IELTS 6.5).

REFEREES

Dr Ella Haig, Associate Professor in AI, School of Computing, University of Portsmouth. Ella.Haig@port.ac.uk. MSc dissertation supervisor and co-author.

Dr Fahad Ahmad, Senior Lecturer, Centre for Cybercrime and Economic Crime, University of Portsmouth. Fahad.Ahmad@port.ac.uk. Taught and assessed me on the MSc.